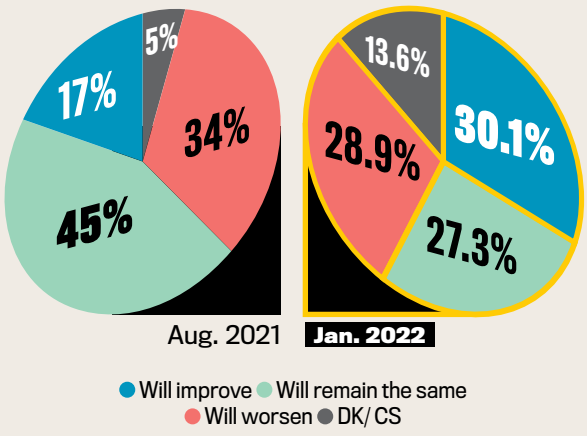
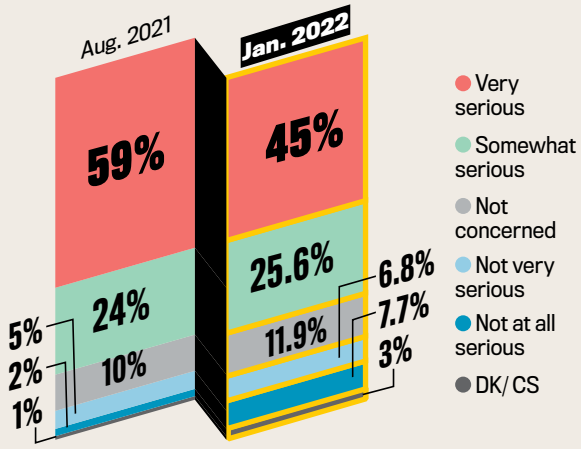
Q. IS YOUR HOUSEHOLD INCOME/ SALARY LIKELY TO IMPROVE?



Q. HOW DO YOU VIEW THE UNEMPLOYMENT SITUATION IN THE COUNTRY?



from 59 per cent in August. Another 25.6 per cent said the situation was 'somewhat serious'.

Shankar Chaudhary, 40, the owner of a garments business in Navi Mumbai, says the past two years have been the toughest he has seen in the two decades he has been in business. He says it is not just the restrictions that have caused trouble, but also the arbitrary manner in which they have been imposed. "There is no clarity as to when you can operate your shop," he says. "After the festival season in November, business has not been good at all." Many MSMEs (micro, small and medium enterprises) tell similar stories, as do retailers. To be sure, their plight is not as bad as it was during the first wave of the pandemic, when there was a complete shutdown for weeks altogether, or even during the second wave, when the Delta variant ravaged the country. But the Omicron wave, arriving just as things were beginning to get better, has created problems for many.

There is a realisation among the general public that restrictions on movement and crowding help contain the spread of the virus. However, it is also true that such measures hurt businesses. As many as 52.8 per cent of those polled said restrictions helped contain the spread but impacted business activity. However, 22.3 per cent of those polled did not think that restrictions impacted livelihoods adversely. In fact, there are several businesses that have done well during the pandemic, such as those in the online space, including e-tailers and food aggregators. The successful IPOs (initial public offerings) from unicorn start-ups such as Zomato, Nykaa and Policybazaar are proof of this trend.

77%
OF RESPONDENTS FROM THE EAST **SAY UNEMPLOYMENT IS A SERIOUS PROBLEM; 56%** OF THOSE FROM THE SOUTH AGREE

However, the story is quite different for physical stores. Night and weekend curfews have hit retail and hospitality hard. The latest MOTN numbers put the general plight of Indians in perspective: as many as 64.1 per cent of those polled said their incomes had fallen, while only 22.7 per cent said there was no change in their incomes. The situation is better compared to the previous three surveys where 85 per cent or more said their incomes had fallen, but that does not offer much consolation as uncertainties related to Covid still linger.

Notwithstanding the hardship, the MOTN poll indicates a general feeling that the government has done enough to counter the worst of the economic damage caused by Covid-19. A slew of measures from the Centre and state governments, especially those targeted at the poor, the farmers and small businesses offered much relief, although